

Running Fair Performance Reviews

Evaluating fairly, motivating, without bias

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Evaluating fairly, motivating, without bias

A performance review can be a motivation lever... or a dreaded, unfair moment. Between biases (halo, recency, affinity), clumsy feedback and vague goals, fairness doesn't come naturally.

This guide helps you spot your evaluator biases, put the review back in service of the person, and adopt a fair method.

Your intention

What seems hardest to you in your reviews: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Your evaluator biases

We rate more favorably what resembles us (affinity), we project, and we sometimes struggle to say things. These often-unconscious biases skew fairness.

Naming them is the condition for fairer evaluation.

Example

Sure he was objective, Marc rated those like him higher. Seeing it let him correct course.

My biases

Which profiles do you tend to rate higher/lower? Why?

What I avoid saying

What do you avoid saying in reviews (out of discomfort)? What does that unsaid cost?

→ *Naming my biases is the condition for a fair review.*

The judgment traps

Halo effect (one quality eclipses everything), recency bias (only the last weeks stick), 'good/bad student' labels: these traps distort the review.

Returning to facts over the whole period corrects course.

Example

About to rate on 'the last mistake', Inès reread her year's notes. The assessment was far fairer.

Halo & recency

For an upcoming review: what could eclipse the rest (a quality, a flaw, a recent event)?

Facts over the whole period

List 3 facts spread across the year (not just recent) to balance your judgment.

→ *I evaluate over the whole period — not the last impression.*

The review serving the person

A good review isn't just rating: it recognizes, grows, gives meaning. Everyone deserves a fair, clear review that's useful for progress.

Evaluating is also supporting.

Example

By turning the review into a development dialogue, Léa saw her team's motivation rise.

Recognize & grow

For one person: what do you want to recognize · what useful growth area to propose?

Give meaning

How to link their goals to something meaningful to them?

→ *Evaluating is recognizing and growing — not just rating.*

A fair method

Concretely: clear criteria and goals defined in advance and shared, balanced and factual feedback (Situation-Behavior-Impact), co-built goals, and a written record.

Method neutralizes much of the bias.

Example

Leaning on shared criteria and concrete examples, Sofia made her reviews both fair and well received.

My criteria & facts

Note: shared criteria/goals · 2 factual examples (S-B-I) per person.

Co-build the next step

Prepare 1-2 questions to co-build the goals and development plan.

→ *On criteria and facts, the review becomes fair.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Define clear criteria and goals in advance (and shared).
- Evaluate on facts covering the whole period, not just the last weeks.
- Beware the halo effect and affinity.
- Balance recognition and growth areas; back each point with an example (S-B-I).
- Co-build the goals and development plan; keep a written record.
- This guide is coaching support, not HR or legal advice.

To fill in

My facts per person

Criterion/goal	Factual example (S-B-I)

Co-build

Upcoming goal	Support to get there

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Spot my evaluator biases.

Week 2 — Defeat halo & recency (return to facts).

Week 3 — Put the review in service of the person.

Week 4 — Apply a fair method.

Your plan in 3 lines

- The bias I watch:
- My shared criteria:
- What I want to recognize & grow:

TO CLOSE

On facts and criteria — a fair, useful review.

On facts and criteria — a fair review.

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